meanings, of the rule of law in theory has also hindered its operationalisation in practice' because of the 'open ended character of the rule of law'.[184] They find this absence of a detailed study of the quality of democracy in Central and Eastern Europe quite disturbing 'for this crisis is truly a systematic one and runs deep in the very mindset and comprehensive modus operandi of the post-communist societies in CEE [Central and Eastern European] countries'.[185] But the most important and quite unique contribution the two authors make to the debate on the democratic backlash in Eastern Europe is to follow. Not only in Poland and Hungary, but also in the rest of the region the rule of law 'appears to have been, since the fall of the Iron Curtain, under attack from *nouveau riche* elites very much connected to the former totalitarian regimes. Old practices of corruption, nepotism, clientelism and "dirty togetherness" have not only not been eradicated, but remain present in the centre of institutional and public space in certain CEE countries. Most of those countries have not undertaken a fully-fledged reform of the rule of law and have retained a post-socialist formal and authoritarian mentality'.[186]

For Avbelj and Letnar Černič, it is about 'fundamental misunderstandings by old member states and EU institutions about the sociopolitical nature of these countries. […] [i]n many ways the outcome of a deliberate, even if benign, neglect of the real sociopolitical state of affairs in these countries by the old member states and Brussels-based institutions out of a desire to make the EU big bang enlargement of 2004 a success story', in which 'to a certain extent the international and supranational political as well as economic alliances played their role too. When these alliances have been undermined or even broken – largely under the duress of the financial and economic crisis that began in 2008 – the Potemkin village of CEE states irreversibly started collapsing too'.[187]

According to the authors, Slovenia is a good example of such a Potemkin village. There, with the exceptions of short spells of government by the centre-right Prime Minister Janez Janša, the country has been for most of the 30 years of independence run by coalitions dominated by various leftist parties and 'the capture of the state by the post-communist left and their economic allies has gone uncriticised, unsanctioned and has been taken as part of the new normal of the slightly peculiar Slovenian capitalist model'.[188] Furthermore, 'the former communist elites have almost